3 Days in Beijing This December

A solo winter route through imperial gardens, the Great Wall, and the city's quiet corners — designed for one traveler under ¥700 RMB.



Made by Kat · Tested on the ground in China

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Contents

01	Trip Overview & Budget
02	Day 1: Western Hills & Summer Palace
03	Day 2: Mutianyu Great Wall
04	Day 3: Jingshan, Shichahai & CBD
05	Practical Tips for Winter
06	Final Notes

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Trip Overview & Budget

Theme: Three Days of Capital — a solo walk from frozen imperial gardens to the Great Wall, then back to the modern skyline.

Best for: First-time visitors who want iconic sights without the crowds, and don't mind cold weather.

Travel style: Independent, low-budget, photo-friendly, slow-paced. No tour groups.

Estimated total budget:

- Day 1 (Summer Palace + food + transport): ~¥110
- Day 2 (Mutianyu transport + entry + slide): ~¥290
- Day 3 (Jingshan + Shichahai + CBD): ~¥60
- Two hostel nights (¥120/night): ~¥240
- Total: ~¥700 (about $95 USD)

Apps you'll use: Amap for navigation, Didi for rides, Alipay/WeChat for payments.

KAT'S TIP

Book Mutianyu tickets online the night before. December is low season, but weekends still see domestic tourists.

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Day 1

Western Hills & Summer Palace



Morning to late afternoon: Spend the whole day at the Summer Palace. In December, Kunming Lake is partially frozen and the Western Hills fade into pale blue — the classic 'Clear Snow on Western Hills' scene.

Route (no backtracking):

- Enter through the New Palace Gate.
- Walk straight to the Seventeen-Arch Bridge and Nanhu Island.
- Stroll the West Causeway for the best lake-and-mountain views.
- Exit from the East Palace Gate, near the subway.

Entry: ~¥20 off-season (park only) or ~¥50 including the palace buildings.

Dinner: Xiyuan area, just outside the East Gate. Try xiaodiaolitang pear soup — pear soup to warm your throat after a cold day.

If it snows: The palace becomes a living ink painting. January is your highest chance, but late December storms happen too.

KAT'S TIP

Wear thick soles. The marble lakeside paths get slippery with frost and ice.

Day 2

Mutianyu Great Wall



Full day. Skip crowded Badaling. Mutianyu has gentler slopes, forested ridges, and far fewer people in winter.

How to get there:

- Take the tourist bus from Dongzhimen or use a Didi ride-share for around ¥120–150 per person round trip if shared.
- Budget option: public bus 916 Express from Dongzhimen to Huairou, then a local taxi to the entrance.

On the wall:

- Take the enclosed cable car up to Tower 14.
- Walk east toward Tower 20 — the most scenic stretch.
- On the way down, take the toboggan slide. You control the speed.

Costs: entry ~¥40 off-season, cable car round trip ~¥120, toboggan ~¥80–100.

Lunch: bring your own bread, nuts and a thermos. There are basic restaurants at the base if you prefer hot food.

KAT'S TIP

The toboggan closes in heavy snow or strong wind. Check with staff before you climb.

Day 3

Jingshan, Shichahai & the CBD Skyline



Morning: Jingshan Park. Exit the Forbidden City from the Gate of Divine Might, cross the road, and enter Jingshan. The 2-yuan climb to Wanchun Pavilion gives the best overhead view of the Forbidden City — red walls and yellow roofs spreading below you.

Midday: Shichahai. Walk the shore of Houhai Lake, watch old men play chess, and duck into a courtyard café. This is old Beijing at its most relaxed.

Late afternoon: Guomao / CBD. Take the subway to Guomao Station. Head to the free public terrace on the north side of China World Mall (Level 6) for the classic CCTV Headquarters ('Big Pants') and CBD sunset shot.

Dinner: Choose between a hotpot restaurant in Shichahai or a food-court meal in Guomao.

KAT'S TIP

On a clear winter day you can see the Forbidden City, Beihai White Dagoba and the CBD towers all from Wanchun Pavilion.

Budget Breakdown

Item	Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Total
Attraction entry	¥50	¥40	¥2	¥92
Transport	¥20	¥120	¥20	¥160
Food	¥80	¥60	¥80	¥220
Cable car / slide	—	¥220	—	¥220
Accommodation	—	—	—	¥240
Total	**¥150**	**¥440**	**¥102**	**¥692**

Prices are estimates for one person in December 2026. Off-season discounts apply. Hostel prices assume a bed in a central shared dorm. If you prefer a private room, add ¥150–250 per night.

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Practical Tips for Winter

Clothing:

- Thermal base layers, a down jacket, wool socks, gloves and a hat.
- Non-slip boots. Marble and stone surfaces are icy.
- Lip balm and hand cream — Beijing winter is dry.

Getting around:

- Subway is the cheapest and warmest option. Fares ¥3–9.
- Didi is cheap and works in English.
- Avoid unlicensed taxis at tourist sites.

Food:

- Hotpot, lamb skewers and pear soup are winter essentials.
- Many restaurants close earlier in winter — check Dianping hours.

Health:

- Air pollution can spike in December. Check the AQI and bring a mask if sensitive.
- Stay hydrated — the heating indoors is intense.

KAT'S TIP

Download Amap and save the Chinese names of each site before you go. It makes Didi pickups much easier.

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You're ready.

Beijing in winter is cold, quiet, and unexpectedly beautiful. The crowds are gone, the light is sharp, and the city belongs to those who dress warm and walk slow.

About this guide

This itinerary was written by Kat at Ready? China! based on real, on-the-ground experience. Prices and opening hours change, so double-check before you travel. If you want a custom route tailored to your dates and pace, message Kat at readychinatravel.com.

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